of music, from a time when listeners enjoyed exactly what the musician offered, we moved to a place where the gap between what the musician rendered and what was finally packaged for the listener widened. Digital technology enabled the alteration of music before the audience heard it. At one time, this was only possible in a recording studio. Now, this technology is sophisticated enough for it to be employed in a live concert. This led to the cleansing of those beautiful accommodations that occur naturally during the making of music.

When Tools Decide

AI has lifted digital technology to the stratosphere. It does not just make me sound better or art look prettier. It decides how I should sound, and makes those decisions on my behalf. Bizarrely, it can become me or somebody else and even manifest art that is imbued with the sensibilities of many artists. As you may have noticed, I seem to be falling into the trap I had warned you about when I began the piece. I have made AI an independent being. In order to stop myself from doing so, let me pose a question. In art creation, what do we seek from the use of AI? Simply put, we want to be the best edition of ourselves. We do not want the world to know our art with our flaws and aberrations. We also want elements that we do not possess. Those things that make us envious of another artist! With all this, we want to create a product that is creaseless, unreal and sanitised, devoid of any human-ness.

What AI takes from each artist is technique and signatures. As we know, forgeries are often 'better' than the original. AI is the world's best-known forger. When AI imitates artists, it gives us what we, as a collective society, believe is an improved version of the artist. In this artificiality lies a truth. We are all dissatisfied with our perceptions of ourselves. And somehow, we have been convinced that AI will fill that vacuum. We do not seek perfection, but a synthetisation. More than wanting a robot to execute our orders, we want to be able to perform like a robot.

AI performs this task stupendously well and, with its quick learning ability, builds on our aspiration for the processed by artificially creating colours, designs, tunes, pictures and stories that take us further down its path. I am told that AI can, if asked, replicate even our artistic imperfections.

TAKEAWAYS

We endow AI with agency, forgetting that true intelligence and consciousness remain uniquely human

Soon, artists may be compelled to make art that fits the 'AI' bill—an inversion of the power balance between machine and artist

In a world AI has decided for us, art won't ruffle feathers, challenge beauty. In other words, art will be dead

This, then, raises an existential question. Is there anything exclusively human in art? I do not have a definitive answer, but I can say that being an artist is not just about creating enjoyable, pretty art objects for other people to savour. Art is a conscious act with an intentionality that comes from a deeply ethical place. It is not about the end product, nor is it concerned with reception. The artist experiences something intangible while making art. In that intimate dialogue between the canvas and the painter, the notes and the musician, the movement and the dancer, art exists. The social interactivity of art is determined by this experience that every artist undergoes. Once this is destroyed, the art object is soulless and has nothing to share with the receiver.

The Receiving End

The audience, on its part, has to ask itself a similar question about what it means to engage with art. Consumption cannot be their driving force. They need to realise their own inextricable relationship with art. A relationship that is not defined by pleasure. Art does not exist in isolated suspension; it is the creation of the artist. Which means, every art experience is one in which the artist—whether present or not—is in conversation with the receiver. Severing this connection negates a fundamental aspect of art, which is communion. Audiences have to think about what they carry within when they watch a person sing or dance, or when an artist expresses their deepest feelings. Only such questions can lead us to any clarity about whether or not art by artists matters.

A world engulfed in AI is morphing all of us. As AI continues to learn and generate spotless and captivating 'art-like' art, our sensory perception is getting more attuned to what AI produces. Soon, artists will need to make art that fits the 'AI' bill. Which is an inversion of the power balance between the machine and the artist. But it does not end here. We will begin to view the world through the prism of what AI has decided is our world. Human behaviour will conform to the demands of the contrived. Homogenisation will be preferred. We might be happy in such a world, and still continue to do all the things we do today, but our relationship with each other and the natural world will be tuned to algorithmic computations. In such a world, art will not ruffle feathers, demolish conformism, challenge beauty and demand imagination. In other words, art will be dead. ■

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